

had the largest resistance force, women—one-seventh of the Polish Home Army's 40,000 members—did take part in combat operations. The Special Operations Executive (SOE), a British unit founded in 1940 to spy and perform acts of sabotage in occupied Europe, had several female agents. One of the most famous was Virginia Hall, who despite her prosthetic leg, operated behind enemy lines in France. Another was Haviva Reik, one of a group of Jewish agents the SOE parachuted into Slovakia in 1944. She helped to organize resistance groups until the parachutists were discovered and killed by the German Army.

Many leading figures in the anti-Nazi movement were women; student Sophie Scholl was sentenced to death in 1943 for distributing anti-Nazi pamphlets. Women also played roles in smuggling Jews out of the reach of the Nazis. Emilie Schindler helped her husband to save the lives of over 1,200 Jews; she risked her life buying goods on the black market to feed them. But the role of women was not always positive; around 3,500 worked in Nazi concentration camps. The most notorious was Irma Grese, a warden at Bergen-Belsen, who was executed after the war for her inhumane treatment of prisoners.



BIOGRAPHY

ANNE FRANK

Born in Frankfurt, Anne and her family fled from Germany to Amsterdam after Hitler's rise to power, but the Nazis soon took control there, too. In 1942, the Franks went into hiding in a secret annex above the offices of Anne's father's business, but were betrayed to the authorities in 1944. Anne was deported to a concentration camp where she died of typhus. Her diary, written between 1942 and 1944, was published by her father, and became one of the best-known Jewish accounts of the Holocaust.



◀ Night witches

Germans nicknamed the Soviet 588th Night Bomber Regiment the "Night Witches." The regiment was initially banned from combat, but was deployed for active service in 1941.